The 30th Degree – Knight Kadosh or the Knight of the White and Black Eagle



No apron is worn.

The cordon is a black watered silk ribbon, four or five inches wide, edged with narrow silver lace and worn across the body, from left to right. The letters “K” and “H” are embroidered in scarlet silk on the front part of the cordon. They are the first and last letters of the Hebrew word “Kadosh.” Also embroidered on the cordon are two Teutonic crosses and a double–headed eagle, his wings extended, holding a poniard in his claws. The two heads and the blade of the poniard are of gold. The handle of the poniard is oval, one–half of it white and the other black. The colors represent the division of good and evil in the universe.

The jewel is a double–headed eagle, with wings spread, and measuring about one inch across from outside to outside of the wings. The eagle rests upon a Teutonic Cross one and a half inches in size. The eagle is of silver, and the cross of gold, enameled with red.

DUTIES

Labor unceasingly for the good of mankind.

LESSONS

Arm yourself with faith in God, love toward your fellow men and knowledge. Great examples are the noblest legacies from the past; they enrich a nation more than wealth or power.

FOR REFLECTION

Are the knightly virtues obsolete in the modern world?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Three skulls, three funeral urns, the mystic ladder, the double headed eagle.

This is the last of the Chivalric Degrees of Scottish Rite Masonry. The lessons are derived from history. The historical figure associated with the legend is Jacques De Molay, the last Grand Master of the Knights Templar, an order created during the Crusades. It was destroyed by Philip IV of France and Pope Clement V in the early 14th century. De Molay was put to death, having renounced his confession which had been extracted under torture. Before his death, he accurately predicted the deaths of both Philip and Clement within a year.

The word Kadosh is Hebrew and Pike says that it means “holy,” hence Knight Kadosh means Holy Knight, or Knight of the Temple. The good and true Knight Kadosh is armed outwardly with steel but inwardly with faith in God, love toward his fellow man and knowledge. The primary purpose of the degree is to make real, in action, the noblest sentiments of man. The Knight Kadosh has as his mission to restore to man all his powers and the whole dignity of manhood and to make true again the ancient description of man that he was made in the image of the Deity.

CEREMONY

In preparation for these arduous duties, the candidate is taken through four apartments. In the first apartment, hung with black, the candidate encounters a tomb with three skulls. Viewing the skulls, he is reminded of what he was taught

as he became a Perfect Master, the uncertainty of life and the inevitability of death. He receives this sober instruction:

Set your house in order, for your life passes with every breath you draw. Death tracks every man like a bloodhound.

He is also told that the reward for those who overcome the dread of death is to "ascend above the terrestrial sphere." The center skull is supposed to be that of De Molay and is wreathed in laurel and amaranths, signifying immortality. The skull adorned with a regal crown is that of Philip and represents tyrannical kings. The third skull is that of Pope Clement and represents unholy, ambitious religious leaders. As a group the skulls portray the history of the human race that constant tragedy of guilty power and murdered innocence. The candidate is warned repeatedly of the seriousness of his undertaking to become a Knight Kadosh and advised

You now hold your fate in your own hands.

The second apartment is that of Sacrifice and is hung with white. In this chamber a grave voice announces the duties of a philosopher and a Knight Kadosh. The candidate learns that the Knights Kadosh "now pursue the good of mankind with feet that never tire and eyes that never sleep." Masonry does not seek to establish a Utopia but rather, a people will have such institutions and government as it is fitted for them to have, and it is important that the candidate should understand that the work of the Knights Kadosh is not the repetition at stated times of a few sentences, and the reception now and then of a Candidate. The double headed Eagle is symbolic of the past and future for in this Apartment the candidate sacrifices his own personal ambitions and desires on the altar of Truth.

The candidate is then hurried to the third apartment and the ordeal of the Frank Judges. The Knight Kadosh accompanying the candidate vouches for the candidate as for himself and is warned by these Supreme Judges that should a penalty be incurred because the candidate breaks his vows, the penalty will be

pronounced on both. A searching inquiry into the candidate's faith ensues by the Frank Judges. Upon a vote, if affirmative, the candidate passes to the fourth apartment.

The fourth apartment is hung with crimson, except in the East which is hung with black embellished with skulls pierced by daggers. The chamber is adorned with white columns. A mausoleum shaped like a truncated pyramid displays a funeral urn wreathed in laurel, a regal crown and a Pope's tiara. The candidate is referred to as a man, upon whom one can depend and also one whose mind and intellect have attained their manhood. He is free from the notions of childhood (1 Corinthians 13:11) and capable of distinguishing the truth and manly enough to follow it. His empire is over himself. Before the urn with the initials of J.B.M., the candidate is reminded that he should be ready to sacrifice his life rather than compromise his integrity or deny truth.



The most elaborate symbol in this degree is the Mystic Ladder. On one side the rungs represent the seven liberal arts and sciences of the ancients – grammar, rhetoric, logic, arithmetic, geometry, music and astronomy.

Grammar

The function of language is to communicate. Communication requires predictability. Predictability demands rules. The rules of a language are its grammar. Thus, after the words themselves, grammar is the most important aspect of human communication. By it we express our moral values and our

understanding of the universe. It is, in fine, the mode of instruction and the foundation of all expression.

Rhetoric

Given a language composed of words and rules, man seeks to use this tool to persuade. By eloquence man seeks to fashion the social world in his image and attain power over others. This is the domain of rhetoric and without it neither moral nor political leadership would be possible.

Logic

Though man may seek to persuade by eloquent speech and impassioned pleas, ultimately his arguments must have behind them the force of reason, else all is, as St. Paul said, “sounding brass or a clanging gong,” or as Shakespeare phrased it, “full of sound and fury, signifying nothing.” Thus is logic the indispensable tool of moral and intellectual leadership.

Arithmetic

The bane of every school boy and the engine of every business, this craft may be called the mother of civilization. Without it we would never have seen the pyramids looming out of the sands of Giza, the magnificent bridges which grace all the world’s great rivers or enticed nature to betray her secrets for our benefit. The ever recurrent theme of numbers in daily life, particularly those which regulated the early agricultural societies, gave to certain numbers a sacred or mystical significance, which, to some, they still possess. For us they have become the symbols of the ancient beliefs and reminders of equally ancient lessons.

Geometry

“The first and noblest of Sciences,” geometry may have been man’s first exercise in abstraction outside of language. The word means “measure the earth,” and this was undoubtedly its first application. As well as practical, it became sacred and all its figures the ancients esteemed to be of religious significance. The greatest of the ancient geometricians was Pythagoras who

preceded Socrates and laid the foundations of modern Western mathematics, philosophy, music and religion. From the deductive regularity of the propositions of geometry, we may see a model for the laws which govern the universe, both physical and moral.

Music

From the discovery of harmonics by Pythagoras derived all of Western music. A pure aesthetic, music has no part in moral instruction. The ancients were uncomfortable with this and created the idea of “the Music of the Spheres” or harmony in the universe; a sort of music of God.

Astronomy

Men counted the stars before they counted sheep. The vault of heaven was a great wonder and beauty to the ancients, as it would be to us if we would but stop and gaze upon it. The wondrous profusion of tiny lights which sparkled upon the great slate of the night sky became man’s tracing board. Upon it he wrote his mythology, divined his future, discerned his fate, planted his crops, named his children. He made it the abode of his gods and his devils. Even today no telescope can capture the wonder of its entirety, beckoning man to search its depths and taste its wonders. Stars, long dead, continue to shed light upon the earth, giving the slightest glimpse of the eternity of the past. He who can stand before such wonders without awe is the true atheist.

Corresponding to the rounds representing the seven Liberal Arts and Sciences, the Mystic Ladder has seven rounds of a more esoteric or mystical significance. Pike approximately corresponds some of them to parts of the Sephirothic Tree of Life from the Kabbalah. The first round represents the Fourth Sephira, Justice; the second, the Fifth Sephira, Benignity; the fifth round, the Seventh and Eighth Sephiroth, Victory and Glory; the seventh, the Third Sephira, Intelligence or Understanding. The other rounds represent the Masonic virtues of Faith, Kindliness, and Patience. The esoteric significance must remain as part of our ritual, confided only to faithful breasts.

As one ascends the Mystic Ladder, rising ever higher in his knowledge, there is the danger of falling, that is, forgetting the lessons taught; but we may ascend again, being strengthened by the experiences of life. Thus, the Ladder is also a symbol of patiently bearing “the storms of evil fortune.”

The skull, cross and crown are the object of discourse. The skull is used as a reminder that before death, rank and privileges disappear. From the skull we only know that someone lived and died, that he was but a man, and that death regarded neither his honors nor his disgraces. The crown represents all those kings and emperors who have usurped or abused power, reigned for themselves and not the people and robbed a free people of their liberty, or quenched the fires of freedom with the blood of patriots. The cross is not a symbol of any particular religion or creed but—when joined with the crown as a symbol of unified church and state—it becomes the patron of ignorance and ally of despotism which in every age has made dupes of men and enslaved humanity through fear and superstition. Rather, the ritual tells us that the people are sovereign over institutions, and that

Sooner or later the hand of God will strike at the heart of spiritual tyranny and despotism.

This is the true meaning of the motto of the Knights Kadosh: Nekam Adonai! “vengeance is Thine, O Lord!”

LECTURE

The lecture follows a different form than either preceding or succeeding lectures. It is essentially an extended quote from an enemy of Masonry who is attempting to associate the Craft and the Knights Templar in an historical, but invidious fashion. Pike has inserted occasional notes but these are largely intended to refute or expand upon a point of his source. Therefore, the duties of a Knight Kadosh, as such, are not readily to be found there. To a far greater extent than in other degrees, Pike is relying on the *Legenda* for this degree to amplify the teachings. These sources are no longer readily available and so the standard

form of presenting the duties of the degree with excerpts from the lecture in *Morals and Dogma* has been modified. Instead there is a summary of the meaning of the duty as taught in the ritual and expanded upon in the *Legenda* of the degree; those quotes from the *Legenda* are identified as such.

War against Ignorance. Knowledge is power. Education expands the intellect and leads man toward an understanding of what truth is. It is the ignorant man who is the slave of his emotions, always ready to follow the cleverest orator and believe in the most corrupted logic. All forms of tyranny are nourished by ignorance. Thus, true freedom is the acquisition of knowledge applied to the practical problems of life.

Ask all the people of the past who have suffered abuses and persecution ... the cost of Ignorance and Fanaticism, and into what deplorable excesses it can lead mankind (*Legenda* XIXXXX, p. 163).

... knowledge alone gives men power; it alone enables a man to be useful, and makes him necessary to the community. Little can be expected from an ignorant man. ...Prejudice and error always hold him in bonds. The well–informed man only is really free. He sees, he understands, he knows. Upon his eyelids shines the True Light, the light of Knowledge, Truth, Philosophy (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 142).

War against Spiritual Tyranny. Spiritual tyranny is intolerance. It presumes to decide for man his earthly and spiritual fate. It promises, and when promises fail, it threatens; when threats fail, it excommunicates and attempts to make its enemies an anathema to their friends and families. It seeks, by division, to conquer the hearts of men that they may serve its ends and cooperate in the preservation of the institution rather than the preservation of its teachings which may themselves be sublime.

Nor did [the Templars] war upon the religion of Rome. They wished only to see limits set to its extravagant claims to temporal power, its intolerable usurpations checked, the knife and actual cautery applied to its rank abuses, the right of

private judgment in matters of faith asserted, and that of every man to worship God in such manner as his own conscience should dictate (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 156).

The Great Order [Templars] naturally revolted against a Church which demanded of its members an absolute surrender of the reason as well as of the will (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 157).

War against Despotism. Despots seek first of all to control men's actions. Fast on the heels of such success comes the attempt to control men's thoughts. Propaganda replaces education and freedom of the press becomes a conspiracy against a well–ordered society. War becomes a tool of distraction, facing a nation outward that it may not see the corruption within. Great sacrifices are demanded in the name of patriotism but the end is only the sacrifices and the distractions they create. The despot conjures up phantoms that they may be feared and fought instead of him.

The Templars made no issue with liberal and well–regulated government. They were not at first, nor are they now, the advocates of radicalism and unbridled popular license, itself the worst of tyrannies; but they do believe that a constitutional Monarchy, or a well–regulated and safely–balanced Republic, based on an inviolable Constitution, expressing the will and having the assent of the people, is the only government to which a moral and enlightened human being ought to submit (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 156).

War against Vice. Vice contends against man's moral nature; its armor is greed, its weapons ambition, fanaticism and superstition. This is a war that man may never win. The final conflict of good and evil may not be fought on this earth. So long as ignorance, weakness and hunger exist, and are exploited, the work of the Knight Kadosh is laid out before him– to make the world a better place than he found it. Reason and knowledge must be our guides. The only true victory is a moral victory.

To assist in this great work [War against Vice] is the noblest enterprise in which human virtue can engage. It is the nobler because it promises only labor and danger, with little expectation of any other reward than the approval of one's own conscience, and that of such Brethren as love the truth; with that of God, from whom Justice and Truth emanate (*Legenda* XIXXXX, p. 161).

To War against Ignorance, Tyranny, Despotism and Vice:

The arms wherewith to war against Tyranny, Superstition and Ignorance, are Knowledge, Virtue and Love, and Charity for mankind (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 161).

Heaven has not denied all remedy for... monstrous abuses. He who created the great suns to light the universe, also created Reason and Knowledge to be our guides, to console us in this awful labyrinth of horrors and calamities. If Fanaticism is fruitful of monsters, heaven has also created virtuous men to do battle with them; and every age, ...has seen arise a Redeemer, by the side of the genius of Malevolence. Heroes, Sages and Friends of Humanity have appeared in almost uninterrupted succession, in all ages, to enlighten and console the world (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 165).

Steadfastness in Adversity. Beginning with the Anti–Masonic movement of his time, Pike illustrates steadfastness by the example of Masonry's renewal in the face of persecution. Masonry, in fact, benefited by these attacks as the weak and vacillating members left the Craft. Only the most sincere and dedicated brethren remained to rebuild Masonry in America.

Much of the lecture is devoted to the persecution and destruction of the Knights Templar. Even their destruction was a moral victory as they have ever since served as an example of the noblest of knightly virtues. Their enemies have served to remind us of the dangers of the union of political and ecclesiastical authority, the shame of greed and that, indeed, the wages of sin are death.

The Anti–Masons, traitors and perjurors [sic] some, and some mere political knaves, purified Masonry by persecution, and so proved to be its benefactors;

for that which is persecuted, grows (*Morals and Dogma*, p. 814).

And thus the warfare against the powers of evil that crushed the Order of the Temple goes steadily on, and Freedom marches ever onward toward the conquest of the world (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, p. 160).

Masonic Vengeance. Personal vengeance, the vendetta, is self–destructive. Masonry does not seek to avenge the wrongs of history by warring against the political and religious institutions which spawned them; rather we war against the vices of which these historical events are only an example.

The feeling of revenge and desire for vengeance, in the bosoms of those Templars who survived when the Order suffered shipwreck, at first personal in their character, soon became ennobled, by being directed against the abuses, of which Philip, Clement and the Hospitallers were the type and embodiment (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, pp. 154–155).

After Philip's death, the fallen Order, reviving under different names, in different parts of Europe, labored to overthrow Royal Despotism and Feudal Oppression. After that of Clement, it sought to thwart the arrogant assumption of temporal power by the Popes, and nurtured throughout Europe, among men of letters, poets and divines, the anti–papal spirit (*Legenda* XIXXXX, p. 155).

Man is Supreme Over Institutions. The great truth expressed in the Knight Kadosh Degree is that individuals are supreme over institutions; thus this degree teaches the political truth of Masonry. This truth, as has already been explained, is constitutional government which, by its checks and balances, protects the individual from the tendency of despotism inherent in all political systems. By its separation from religious ties man's political life is freed from the promise and the threat of spiritual rewards and punishments. The Italian poet Carducci, a contemporary of Pike, commented on the separation of church and state:

When Caesar shakes hands with Peter,

Human blood flows;

When the Church and the Empire embrace,

The star of a Martyr is lit in the heavens.

Pike continues the theme of the independence of political institutions, observing that the same great truth is

... the right of the people of every State to govern themselves, and to adopt or continue only such institutions of government as shall seem to themselves best suited to their condition. ... The heart of man craves only justice and love. Men are good. Evil institutions alone have made them bad; and it is the duty of Masonry and of every Knight to aid in leading them back to the truth (*Legenda* XIX–XXX, pp. 168–169).